

Section C: Writing (40 marks)

Students will write a 240–280 words essay, in French, in response to a short stimulus written in French, that relates to one of the general topic areas (GTAs) featured in Section 2.

Students will have individual control over the pace of this examination, including the listening element.

A CD recording will be provided for each student with the examination paper. Centres must ensure that students have access to equipment that permits individual listening (e.g. a CD player with headphones).

2.3 Assessment criteria

General guidance on using levels-based mark schemes

There are two levels-based mark grids to be applied to the essay. The mark grids are:

- content and communication (AO2)
- quality of language (Accuracy and range of lexis) (AO3).

Deciding on a marking band

- First of all, the examiner will consider the essay as a whole and then decide which descriptors most closely match the answer and place it in that band. The descriptors for each band indicate the different features that will be seen in the student's answer for that band.
- When assigning a band, the examiner will look at the overall quality of the essay and not focus disproportionately on small and specific parts where the student has not performed quite as well as the rest. If the answer covers different aspects of different bands of the mark scheme, the examiner will use a 'best fit' approach for defining the band.

Using grids with a range of marks within bands

- Then, the examiner will use the variability of the response to help decide the mark within the band that they have selected. For example, if the response is predominantly band 5-8 with a small amount of band 9-12 material, it would be placed in band 5-8 but be awarded a mark near the top of the band because of the band 9–12 content.
- The examiner will modify the mark based on how securely the trait descriptors are met at that band.

Content and communication (AO2)

This mark grid assesses students' ability to understand and respond in writing to written language.

Mark	Content and communication (AO2)
0	No rewardable material.
1–4	- The student has shown minimal ability to express ideas relevant to the narrative, report or description required, and ideas hardly follow a logical sequence. - The piece is rarely coherent and there is so much digression that the overall theme or purpose of the piece is greatly obscured.
5–8	- The student has shown some basic ability to express ideas in a form that would be comprehensible to a native reader, with only occasional evidence of ideas following a logical sequence. - The piece is occasionally coherent and while there is some digression from the topic, the overall theme or purpose is generally clear.
9–12	- The student has shown a moderate ability to express ideas in a form that would be comprehensible to a native reader, and some evidence of ideas following a logical sequence. - The piece is sometimes coherent and there is digression from the topic, but the overall theme or purpose is clear.
13–16	- The student has shown a good ability to express ideas in a form that would be comprehensible to a native reader, with much evidence of ideas following a logical sequence. - The piece is mostly coherent and while there may be occasional ambiguity or digression from the topic, these appear to be aberrations in an otherwise pertinent piece of work.
17–20	- The student has shown an excellent ability to express ideas in a logical sequence, and errors do not interfere with the comprehension. - The piece is entirely coherent and while there may be very minor ambiguities or digression from the topic, the piece is confident, fluent, pertinent and purposeful.

Quality of language (Accuracy and range of lexis) (A03)

The following mark grid assesses students' ability to apply grammar and syntax accurately, and the ability to use a range of lexis and structures.

Mark	Quality of language (A03)
0	No rewardable language.
1–4	- Limited range of vocabulary and grammatical structures, which are rarely used appropriately and effectively to address the needs of the task. - Lexis and grammar may not be accurate, with a high degree of repetition.
5–8	- Adequate but predictable range of vocabulary and grammatical structures, only occasionally used appropriately and effectively to address the needs of the task. - Lexis and grammar are occasionally accurate.
9–12	- Satisfactory range of vocabulary and grammatical structures, sometimes used appropriately and effectively to address the needs of the task. - Good control of basic language, but there may be errors particularly with more complex structures/lexis.
13–16	- Good range of vocabulary and grammatical structures generally used appropriately and effectively to address the needs of the task. - Only occasional lapses in lexical and grammatical control.
17–20	- Wide range of vocabulary and grammatical structures used appropriately and effectively to address the needs of the task. - Very good control/accuracy with very few errors.